

Letters Sent Across Time

Dear Kaleb in One Month,

How are you? I hope this letter finds you well.

You just graduated, yes? How are you feeling, being done with school? It must feel so weird. It probably hasn't sunk in for you yet. It probably just feels like summer break for you right now. It'll still be a few months, I think, until it fully sinks in. I know it will be for me right now. I know that for certain.

How are mom and dad handling your graduation? I know they're probably gonna be a mess, even if they don't show it. I'm worried mom is going to feel especially emotional about it, since she was my teacher for all those years.

They're proud of you, you know. I hope you know that.

Sincerely,

Kaleb Stone.

Dear Kaleb in Six Months,

How are you? I hope this letter finds you well.

How does it feel being out of college, a few months later? It must be a huge change, after all. I imagine by now it's truly sinking in, since you'd be heading back right around now if you were still enrolled. I've gotten so used to being here these past four years, I've come to think of it as a true second home. Despite being home, do you feel homesick? Hopefully some of your friends from school are keeping in contact with you. You should make sure you're trying to stay in contact with them.

I hope, with all my heart, that you don't think back on your college experience with regret. I hope you don't feel like you wasted your chance. I'm worried I will, when the time comes, but I hope I can face graduation with a smile.

Did you land a job? I've been applying to several but haven't gotten any positive responses yet. They haven't offered me a single interview, and most of them haven't even responded at all. It's quite disheartening.

Have you submitted your writing anywhere yet? I know I've been thinking about where to submit after college, so I hope you've gone through with at least one. If not, you should get on that! Submit to the minnesota review, at least, since you've worked closely with the journal already!

Sincerely,

Kaleb Stone.

Dear Kaleb from Four Years Ago,

Hello! If I remember correctly, you're feeling pretty nervous about going to college right about now. Don't let the nerves get to you too badly, it's going to be fun!

While that is certainly true, do ready yourself. Classes are going to be easier than you fear they will be, but they will absolutely add to your stress. You're going to make a lot of friends in Studio 72, but those friendships will also lead to incredibly hardship. Overall, it will be fun, but it will also be scary and stressful, but not quite in the ways you think it will be now.

You will cry when you're left alone in your dorm room for the first time, after your parents return home. Your heart will drop to the abyss when you think that one of your friends may be dead from an overdose – but he is okay, relatively speaking. You will have a breakdown near the end of your second semester when you realize you've missed out on applying for a summer job, but know that your parents will be there for you, and that it isn't the end of the world.

Now, get ready, go off, and have the time of your life. Savor it, lest it pass you by before you know it.

Sincerely,

Kaleb Stone.

Dear Kaleb in Two Years,

How are you? I hope this letter finds you well. God, it's been a while, hasn't it?

I hope you have a job by now, is it going well? Have you met anybody fun or interesting since college? I hope so.

Is the novel coming along smoothly? I haven't worked on it as much as I'd like to recently, so I hope you've made a lot of progress since graduating. I also hope you've gotten back into reading on your own. School has absorbed most of my motivation to read and write for a while now, so I hope graduating has gotten you back on top of things.

How are mom and dad doing? I worry about them nowadays, especially mom, since her health has never been the greatest. Do you still live with them? I know I'm heading back there after college, but beyond that I don't really have a plan, so I'm curious what your living situation is right now.

Money has been pretty messed up recently, so I hope that's gotten better. The economy in general has hopefully gotten better.

What are your biggest interests right now? Have they changed much since college ended?

Have things gotten better? Is the world a less scary place? Tell me about it, if you have the time – if you have the heart.

Sincerely,

Kaleb Stone.

Dear Kaleb in One Decade,

How are things? I hope this letter finds you well.

Time is a terrifying thing. For as long as I can remember, I've been horrified by the prospect of aging. Right now, I find myself at the cliff of adulthood, and I am scared. So, ten years out, how is it? You're older now, so how do you feel about aging? How do you feel about your life thus far? I'm scared I won't like the answer all that much. I'm terrified of it, even.

Speaking of aging, god I hope mom and dad are still alright.

I hope things are still okay for you and everyone you love.

I hope the world is a better place, with less evil people in it making it worse for everybody else.

I hope you're still friends with everyone, stick close to them whenever the world seems scary.

I hope you still hope. Please carry that light in your heart forever.

Sincerely,

Kaleb Stone.

Dear Kaleb in the Far Future,

...are you still there?

Sincerely,

Kaleb Stone.

Add more letters! More letters addressed to the past would be great. One or two farther back, maybe one that's 2-3 years ago. 3 years ago could be especially interesting.

Give more context from the present before asking questions about the future. (could maybe also do this through past letters)

More present stuff as a sort of record. What would I not remember in X years? More concrete language.

Letters read as too broad right now. They feel a bit rushed.

What, specifically, am I worried about at any time?

Delve more into the economic/political context as well.

It does feel very relatable. The general concern does resonate with a lot of people, especially people who are graduating right now.

Maybe be a bit more specific about the ending? Make it further in the future. Right now, it kind of reads as a joke. Put more of the feelings behind that across in the essay. Keep it the same but lead up to it in a stronger way.

Could come back to this piece as time goes by and add responses.

There could be a letter addressed to either yesterday or tomorrow to elaborate on the stresses and anxieties of the current moment.

Could lean into the difficulty or imagining the future.

Do you still like ____? But be more specific.

The piece is missing the "Kaleb specificity"

Could write to myself before I was born.

Dear Kaleb when you _____ could be another idea. (eg. Dear Kaleb When You Next Get Rejected From a Job,)

Could be an "explosive" letter

"I hope this letter finds you when you need it"

Lean into talking to different aged Kalebs in different ways